

As The World Burns

C-ROK Pirate Radio 2076 – SCRIPT

[cut]

TOMMI

Hello hello, you lovely people, you're listening to C-ROK London. My name is Tommi Starr and this is "As The World Burns", your weekly hour-or-so of retro rock goodness coming to you from a secret location *quite* near the Thames, playing you tunes I found in my granddad's loft, while the planet swirls inexorably further and further down the crapper.

And on that note...

SONG: FAITH NO MORE – ASHES TO ASHES

TOMMI

From 1997, that was "Ashes to Ashes" from a band called Faith No More. What a rather splendid name for a band. It's evocative, that is. It makes you think "Faith... no more? But why? What happened...? You had faith, but now you don't... What was the final straw that destroyed your faith completely?"

Politicians, probably.

Am I right?

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Hey, this is Tommi Starr on "As the World Burns". OK, so if you're new here let me bring you up to speed. It's story time, children.

My granddad was a musician. He played guitar in rock bands back in the 2000s, I think. My dad says granddad just loooooooved his rock music. It was all he would listen to, day in day out. He lived and breathed those bands with the leather jackets and big hair and all that. He was one of them, you know? He wasn't famous or anything, his job was something in computers and he did alright, but outside of work that was his life, you know?

Anyway, he died in 2027, like 15 years before I was born so I never knew him, but the way my dad talks about him he sounded like a really cool dude. So last year I was over at my dad's place (which was granddad's place before), and we were talking about granddad, and he says "Oh hey Tommi, you'll like this, I found some of my dad's music collection in the loft" and he brings out this box of discs. They're rock albums from, like, 80 years ago, some of it stuff you still hear on some of the crustier oldies stations, bands with names like "The Electric Boys" and "Danger Danger". Granddad had obviously played these things to death, man. Some of the discs were worn and scratched, and the little inlays were torn and faded... he loved these albums, man.

So anyway, my dad can't play these discs and neither can I, no-one we know can, so I just take them home and check them out when I'm having a beer... you know, read the inlays and that, read the lyrics, get to know who played guitar in Extreme and who sang for Little Angels... and I start to obsess over these things.

Then, get this, about a month later my buddy Bob Solid gets a job as a teacher in a nearby school, which is hilarious. If you knew Bob you would NOT let him into a school, never mind have him teaching anything, but he is handy with technology and fixing stuff which helped him get the job I guess. Anyway, he's been there a week or two and then he has to give a lesson on historical technology, and that weekend he's telling me about it in the pub, and he says "Oh yeah, and we have all these ancient music players in the storeroom, like from before holotapes? There's players for these huge reels of magnetic tape, gizmos that will play wax cylinders, all kinds of disc players and readers..." and I cut him off right there. I whipped out one of my granddad's discs from my pocket - "Slave to the Grind" by Skid Row, in fact - and said "Wait, can you play these things?" and Bob says "Yep, definitely!"

Listener, I was shook.

We downed our beers, legged it out the door and sprinted home, picked up the box of discs, and hoofed it down to the school. Well Bob's a genius when it comes to connecting things to other things, and within a few hours we had a large chunk of my granddad's music collection on holotape. Man that was a night.

Next day I went over to dad's house and told him all about it, and played him a couple of tracks... but he did NOT dig it. He said "Tommi, if I want to listen to that crap I'll put on an oldies station. I found that box and I knew you would get a kick out of it, but it's not for me. It's music of the past. It was my father's thing, not mine." Huh.

Then wind forward to earlier this year, 2076. I was in a dive bar down by the river and I got talking to some guy who says he runs a pirate radio station here in London. Naturally my interest was piqued, being a music guy, and I told him I'd always wanted to be on the radio. So we got chatting, and it turned out he runs not just any pirate radio station, but the mighty C-ROK! You can probably guess the rest. I told him about the discovery of my granddad's music collection, we split a bottle of wine, and cooked up the idea for "As The World Burns". So now, here I am every Saturday night from 10pm, playing you the rock music from my dead granddad's loft. Music that makes me smile in a world that... really doesn't.

I hope you get a kick out of it. I sure do. And if you don't... well... that radio dial is yours to command. You dig?

OK, enough waffle for now. I'm gonna grab a beer. Here's a song from the year my granddad was born - 1974, if you can believe it. 102 years ago. This is Deep Purple with "Burn".

SONG: DEEP PURPLE - BURN

TOMMI

Rest in peace, granddad. You rock.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

I tell you what, my dear listener, I woke up this morning, went and appraised myself in the mirror, and I stood there and I said to myself, I said "Self! It's a great day for rock and roll!"

But it wasn't. I went to make myself some breakfast, and the toaster exploded. That terrified my cat, who screeched into the other room and knocked my flatmate's wine all over her ruining another dress and her favourite book, which she then hurled at my head. I ducked, the book hit a lamp, which went over and smashed, and a spark set fire to the sofa. Again.

Anyway, I found the song I was looking for the other day - get this down you.

SONG: DREAM THEATER - UNDER A GLASS MOON

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: This is a long one, by the way.)

TOMMI

That's "Under a Glass Moon" by Dream Theater, from 1992. Love that.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

As you may be aware, here on "As The World Burns" I play you music from my granddad's collection, and among the few notes he left behind he very specifically points out that there is no music by Bon Jovi anywhere in his collection, and never was. I don't know what his problem was with Bon Jovi, but to honour him I am declaring the **"As The World Burns" Non Jovi Guarantee.**

You will never hear a Bon Jovi song on this show, guaranteed, or your money back.

Well, there is no money and this is a pirate radio station so we do what the hell we want, but you get the point.

This is Black Veil Brides.

SONG: BLACK VEIL BRIDES - I AM BULLETPROOF

TOMMI

Niiiiice, nice nice nice. I doubt he was actually bulletproof, though.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

What's going on out there, listener? Man, I dunno. The world scares me these days. It's nothing new though... I was 10 when the UN collapsed and Europe went to war with the Middle East over oil. School already sucked but wondering if a missile was going to land on the playground while we played football at break time really boosted the suck factor exponentially. We survived that, and then when I was 18, the war ended with both sides losing when the oil ran out anyway and the whole European Commonwealth descended into civil war, which has been rumbling on ever since. They say the only oil left now is in Alaska, hence the whole Canadian annex business and the war between America and China, which has been going on for what? A decade now...? That's still terrifying on a daily basis...

Sheesh. Um... Aaaaaanyway... next up, on the subject of war, it's Bon Jovi!

(Maybe record scratch effect, and pause the music bed?)

pause

Just kidding.

SONG: PANTERA - MOUTH FOR WAR

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: This is Pantera. Had you going though...)

TOMMI

Yeah so they say that the Chinese are starting to surrender now, because the Americans have that powered armour? I mean... that *sounds* good, on the surface, but I dunno man... something doesn't sit right about it. Wars tend to carry on until one side is wiped out, or can't continue, and to my knowledge... war never changes.

wind sound effect

Ah... what do I know? I just play the music.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

I want to give a shout out to my pal George all the way over the pond in Boston. George and I go way back. His dad works for West-Tek or Wattz or one of those American "hardware companies", if you get me, he was like the UK sales liaison or something, and he was based here in London back in the 2040s. George and I went to school together for a few years before his dad moved them back to Boston in the 50s for work. We've stayed in touch though, and George is doing alright. He says he's got a job working for Nuka Cola as a sales rep. Why they need sales reps for that stuff I dunno, I think every American human that can hold a bottle drinks it 24/7 as far as I can tell, but anyway he sounds happy enough. I told him I found my granddad's music and I'm doing this show, and he requested - nay, demanded - that I send him some recordings of it.

You have a deal, my good buddy. This weekend I'm gonna make you some holotape compilations of some of the best bits and get them sent over to you. Enjoy, man! Maybe you could send over a crate or two of fizzy goodness? Probably not, I gather they're really tight on that. In fact George told me a couple of weeks ago that there's some really really hush hush top secret project going on at Nuka Cola. I probably shouldn't say this on the radio, but screw it. Where's that message I got? ... Here it is. Yeah, he says:

"`Sup Tommi, have you made those tapes of your radio show yet? Work's getting super busy and I need a distraction. There's some ultra top-shelf closed-doors black-ops project going on over here at the Nook and it's all hands on deck. I don't know all the details myself, and I can't tell you the stuff I do know 'cause they made me sign away my soul (and the potential souls of any children I may have in the future), so all I will say is people should get ready for a new blue taste in their lives... but don't quote me on that!"

Ah shit, sorry man, I just did. On the radio too. Um. Well, I don't expect the top brass in Bradburton or wherever listen to pirate radio from London, so you should be safe, dude!

Anyway - this one's for you George - check it out. And stay safe!

SONG: LOVE/HATE - WASTED IN AMERICA

TOMMI

Love/Hate there from 1992 with "Wasted In America". Tell you what, people of America... how about you spend a bit more time getting wasted and relax a bit, and maybe put a bit less time into invading everyone in your address book, huh?

shudder

Enough of that. On with the show!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Big news on the show this week, my faithful listener. Grab a cuppa and strap in.

So, you know how the whole premise of this show is that I play you upbeat rock tunes from a bygone generation that came from my granddad's music collection? Well if you didn't, you do now. Anyway I got a very excited phone call from my dad on Monday saying I should come round when I could, and I should bring the disc player I got from Bob. Colour me intrigued! Well what else was I doing? I put leather to pavement and rocked up at his door an hour later, and to say I've never seen my dad this excited is something of an understatement. He looked like he was going to explode, or sneeze, or pop his clogs, or all three at once. I thought he'd forgotten to take his pills or maybe he'd been chugging coffee all morning again, but no. I said "Why did you want the disc player? Did you find another box of discs or something?"

"Nope," he says. "Better than that!" And he's like, quivering. I can tell it's something big. I said "Well come on then, before you give yourself a heart attack", and I swear he giggled like a schoolgirl. So he goes over to the sofa and reaches behind it, and reveals what looks like an old guitar case.

"It's a guitar case" I said, waiting for the punchline.

He shook his head a bit, and then he dropped the bomb. "It's *granddad's* guitar case. And *his guitar is in it.*"

He flicked the catch and opened up the case, and I swear bright light shone out of it and angels sang. Inside this guitar case - which is lined with bright pink fur, by the way - is the brightest coloured electric guitar I have ever seen. It's neon green, with pink bits, and yellow knobs, and it looks like... ok imagine you take every picture of the 1980s you can find in the history books, and chuck them all in a blender. It looks like the 1980s threw up. But... it also looks really really cool, somehow. And it kind of looks like one of those old sports cars? Like it's a guitar, and it's not moving, but it still appears to be going 90 miles an hour. It says "Ibanez" on the head end bit and dad reckons it was made in 1987. Apparently it was in a hidden cupboard in the loft that dad didn't even know was there. He reckons granddad hid it there from grandma, but he won't say any more about that. Whatever. I don't play guitar, and dad's a piano guy so neither of us can get a tune out of it, but it still sounds like it works ok, so I dunno, maybe I'll learn? Message the show if you teach guitar in London!

Anyhow, as awesome as all that is, it still didn't explain why I had the disc player with me... until he lifted the guitar out and opened a pocket in the case, revealing a music disc which says on it "Indigo Down - Still

Alive". Dad looks me right in the eye - "This is his band - granddad plays on this!"

OK so now I get it. We whip out the disc player, hook it up to dad's speakers and - so carefully - insert the disc and hit play. I'll tell you the truth, I was kind of dreading hearing it. What if it was shit?

Listener, I needn't have worried. It was really good. But I tell you what, don't take my word for it - check this out:

SONG: INDIGO DOWN - OUT OF MY HEAD

TOMMI

So there you go. That's my granddad's band, Indigo Down, with "Out of My Head", from 2021. Message the show if you dig it! There are four more songs on the disc, and if you like this one, listener, I'll play the rest in future shows.

Rock on granddad.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

What the hell is going on in Alaska? I know what the news tells us over here, but I don't think we get the whole story sometimes, you feel me?

So China invades Alaska ten years ago chasing oil, the US re-invents the tin soldier and sends them in which seems to work for a bit, Canada understandably gets the hump with Iron Men stomping all over the place and when they kick up about it and say "Excuse me, could you not eh?" the US just takes Canada for itself, which frankly tracks. So Canada is no more, it's now just more of the USA, and... Alaska? That's what this is all about, after all, isn't it? That's where the oil is. That's what China wanted in the first place.

The news says that America is getting the upper hand over there thanks to their tin men, but I dunno. On the one hand I'm glad it's a long way away from London, but then again... if it does all kick off, is anywhere far enough away to be safe?

A sobering thought. Probably best to have another beer or three, then. This is Pride & Glory with "A Horse Called War".

SONG: PRIDE & GLORY - A HORSE CALLED WAR

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: Slick link huh? I do think about these things sometimes, you know...)

TOMMI

"Yeeeeeeeah" indeed.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

So, my granddad left a handful of notes with his music collection, and one of them concerns Mr. John Oswald Osbourne, better known as Ozzy. Apparently he was the singer in a band that "invented heavy metal", and they were called Black Sabbath. Granddad didn't write anything about them and I don't have any of their music, so I can't tell you. But he says that Ozzy was known as "The Prince of Darkness" and went on to leave this huge band, Black Sabbath, and go on to launch a solo career to massive unparalleled world-straddling success, despite - and granddad wrote this bit in capitals - NOT BEING A GOOD SINGER.

It is alleged (by my granddad anyway) that Ozzy surrounded himself with amazing musicians, who by extension, made him sound awesome. I dunno, see what you reckon. This is "Desire".

SONG: OZZY OSBOURNE - DESIRE

TOMMI

I dunno man, he sounds alright to me. What's your problem, granddad?

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

The other week I was at a party down by the river with my pal Bob. We'd had a few beers... well alright, we'd been drinking all night, and someone passed me something to smoke, and Bob had a few of his "special mushrooms" out of his jacket pocket and maybe he gave me a couple too, and anyway, it got so late it got early, so we went up onto the roof to see the sun come up. Bob reckoned you could look right at it if you got a thick piece of smoked glass and squinted through it or something, but there was no way I was going to risk my eyesight, even in that state. So the sun came up slowly, like it does, and there was like some wispy thin cloud in front of it, and it looked really beautiful. I was just kind of spacing out, gazing into the distance through my half closed eyes and my sunglasses, mind empty, and this girl next to me says "hey is your friend alright?" And I turn to look at Bob, and he's laying on the ground looking upside down at the sun with his thumbs in his eyes, making a weird burbling noise.

I said "Bob, fella, are you good?" And he says "Yeah man... I'm ok, but from here it looks like I'm being sucked into a black hole or something..."

Classic Bob. Anyway, it made me think of this song.

SONG: SOUNDGARDEN - BLACK HOLE SUN

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: Oh, and one of his boots had just vanished... We never found it.)

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

You know what makes me angry, listener? I mean, yeah, the obvious things like losing my keys, or my bike being stolen, or coming home to find that someone has left a goat's head and spinal column nailed to my door AGAIN... that's all just standard stuff.

What really gets up my nerves of late is people who don't listen. Everyone's on transmit all the time, they don't listen to you. They don't listen to the answer to the question they just asked, half the time. Now I get that this is a little ironic, coming from the guy who is transmitting this show, but that's one of the things I love about being on the radio. You can't interrupt me.

Interrupting someone is rude. Talking over them is rude. I get that there are times when you have to jump in and yell "DUDE LOOK OUT YOU'RE GOING TO RUN OVER SOME DUCKS" or something, that's fine. It was time sensitive and if you hadn't interjected... well we'd be looking for a big bowl of hoi sin right about now. But if someone's just talking, and you think of something you want to say back to them, it is *your* job to *remember* it until they pause! It's basic manners! Don't just blurt out your unprocessed reckon because a thing I said rang a tiny little crappy bell in the dark shitty cupboard of your mind!

It makes me furious. But I still don't think I will ever be as angry as *these* fellas.

SONG: RAGE AGAINST THE MACHINE - KILLING IN THE NAME

TOMMI

That is a very very angry song, and with good reason. I looked it up. It was written about race-motivated police brutality in the 1990s. That shit *should* make you angry.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Ok, my dear listener, with no preamble - see what you make of this.

SONG: PRIMUS - JERRY WAS A RACE CAR DRIVER

TOMMI

It's weird... but I love it. That's Primus, it would seem.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Granddad died in 2027, so naturally there's no music in his collection from then on. Dad tells me he started losing his hearing a year or two before that, so I guess that's why he stopped collecting music. The most recent music in the box comes from 2024 I think, including this one by Linkin Park.

SONG: LINKIN PARK - OVER EACH OTHER

TOMMI

Linkin Park with "Over Each Other" from 2024. What a great voice. That's really something. I dig it.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

I remember when I was a kid, something major would happen and people would like, notice. Like, it would register. Example - remember in the 2050s, when we heard about "The New Plague" over in America? I was 11 or so and suddenly out of nowhere it was all over the news. Apparently like tens of thousands died from that thing, and the US set up a national quarantine. It was big stuff, and even over here people were worried. People adapted their behaviour, and took notice, you feel me?

Nowadays, it seems like the actual sky is falling, and no-one bats a bloody eyelid. I mean... I suppose you can only stay on maximum alert for so long before the cortisol receptors burn out. It's panic fatigue. It's anxiety blindness, brought on by too much damned anxiety.

In the last year, there have been credible reports that the Chinese have developed stealth submarines - INVISIBLE SUBMARINES with NUKES, mind you - and no-one seems to be bothered. I've heard the Americans have developed a shoulder-mounted missile lobber that flings miniature nukes about the side of your head. We're apparently fine with that. You must have heard rumours about a manufactured lab-grown virus the eggheads are working on that speeds up and forces evolution? Yeah yeah, business as usual.

People, this shit is *not* normal! Heavy stuff is afoot! I'm mad as hell, and... and... and I don't like it!

SONG: POISON - THE SCREAM

TOMMI

Stealth submarines? Ghost Fleet. I'm telling you.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

OK right, this is driving me crazy, I have to tell you this, listener. It's making my mind itch. I have to speak my brains, or they will leak out of my ears.

I have this good buddy, Bob Solid. I've mentioned him on the show a few times, he doesn't mind. I know he doesn't listen to the show much, and that's fair enough. You'd never know it but he's a classical music guy. If I go round and bang on his door, I can usually hear violins and clarinets and that pouring out of his speakers. He loves him some Beethoven, or whatever. Not my jam at all, dude, and he doesn't dig the tunes I play on here. No skin off my stylish nose.

So anyway, Bob. We've been mates for years, we hang out all the time, he was even over at my place yesterday wanting to borrow some soap and looking for golf balls for some reason... I see him quite a bit, you feel me? So, I kind of think I know the guy, I have a reasonable idea what's going on in his life. Not in his head, I hasten to add. I will never have the faintest clue what's happening in the otherworldly space between that man's ears. But as it turns out, I didn't know as much as I thought about my good buddy Robert.

Why do I say this? OK. This afternoon I dropped by his place to try and cadge a can of tuna so I can feed my cat this weekend, and I said "Hey man, so do you want to go grab a beer after my show tonight?" Not an uncommon occurrence, we often go down to this little bar overlooking the Thames on a Saturday night when I finish, but he says to me "Uh, I can't tonight man, I'm uh... I'm getting married tomorrow."

record scratch

stunned pause

I assumed he had some epic joke lined up, so I'm waiting for the other sock to pop, and he's just fidgeting and looking sheepish... and I realise he means it! I didn't even know he was seeing anyone, and he's getting married tomorrow???

"You what?" I managed, and he says "Yeah man, I've been wanting to tell you. I met this girl a few months ago at one of the food riots - she had this really cool Captain Cosmos t-shirt and a Grogna mask and blood pouring down her face and shit - and we got talking, and she's into loads of the same stuff I like, and she's really into classical music and electronics and we've been seeing each other ever since and... man... I love her."

Once I'd managed to gather my jaw from the floor, I said "Dude, I'm so happy for you, but why in the jumping jimmies didn't you tell

me???" So now he goes *really* sheepish, and won't look at me, and sticks his hands in his pockets, and he mumbles something that I can't quite make out, and eventually I get him to say it loud and clear:

"She's your sister."

another stunned pause

TS: "You've been seeing my sister?"

BS: "Yeah."

TS: "My sister Lois?"

BS: "Yeah."

TS: "Who I haven't seen since she left home when she was like 20?"

BS: "Yeah."

TS: "You've been seeing my sister, who I haven't seen in I dunno, maybe 15 years?"

BS: "Yeah."

TS: "For MONTHS? And you LOVE her? And you're going to MARRY her?"

BS: "Yeah. See this is why I didn't want to tell you, man. I thought it might fuck up your chi like this. Lois agreed, she said you'd probably get all... twitchy, she said."

TS: "Well, sorry Bob, if I get a little "twitchy" when I find out my best mate can't go out for a beer tonight because tomorrow he's marrying my long lost sister!"

...and I'm not proud to say it listener, but I grabbed a beer (and some tuna) from Bob's fridge and stormed out of there, then came straight here to C-ROK HQ. But here's the thing, while I was stomping along I calmed right down. Bob's right, and I reacted exactly as he predicted, and you know what, if they're happy, then good luck to 'em.

But that's not the end of this little tale, dear listener. When I got to work this evening someone had left a note for me. I'll read it to you.

It says:

Tommi. I know I haven't seen you in years and we weren't on the best of terms when I left, but I've been back in London now for about six months. I haven't been to see Dad yet... but I've left him a note too, and maybe I'll see him tomorrow... and I hope I'll see

you tomorrow as well. I've met someone really special back here in London, and they mean the world to me. It's your friend Bob. I know it's a lot all at once, but it would really mean everything to me if you could come to St. Jez-in-the-Fields church tomorrow at midday. We're going to be married, and you're my brother Tommi. You're my family. If you and dad could both be there, it would be my perfect day. Lois.

So dear listener, that was my Saturday afternoon. Can you top that for casual weekend mindfuckery?

This one goes out to two very special people... my best pal of many many years and very soon to be brother-in-law Bob Solid, and my long lost prodigal sister Lois. This is Living Colour. Cheers.

beer can sound

SONG: LIVING COLOUR - LOVES REARS ITS UGLY HEAD

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: I'm not crying, you're crying!)

TOMMI

I love you guys. I'll see you tomorrow, Sis.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

I was talking to my dad the other day about all this that's going on in the world right now, you know, the whole "Will civilisation get wiped away while I'm drooling into my pillow?" kind of background terror that we all live with on a daily basis nowadays. He says granddad used to talk about "the four minute warning" being a thing when he was at school. Apparently, according to granddad, if China or Russia woke up in a bad mood one day in the 1980s and I dunno, stubbed their toe really hard, and said "Right that's it, I'm nuking London" and they hit their big red button, there would only be like four minutes between our systems detecting incoming missiles and jolly old Blighty being reduced to molten glass. Cheery, huh?

I was sure I had a song here to play that had molten glass in the title but I can't find it now... I've got "Glass Onion", "Glass Prison", "Glass Sandwich"... dammit. It was something glassy...

OK, never mind that. This is "The Threat".

SONG: SKID ROW - THE THREAT

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: Still on topic, innit!)

TOMMI

Won't beg, won't bleed, the man said. Listen to him, people! A-men!

That was Skid Row for you there, here on "As the World Burns". Stay tuned, listener. There's plenty more where that came from.

[cut]

[cut]

SONG: BRIDES OF DESTRUCTION - I GOT A GUN

TOMMI

Yeah, I got a gun too. So watch it. If you see me out on the street, keep your distance, man. Don't mess, you feel me? Step back, my dude.

Well, I got what looks like a gun under my jacket, anyway.

I mean... it's carved out of soap and painted black... but y'know...

Hey, it was convincing enough to chase off a mugger in the street last week so y'know, it did its job.

I hate guns, man.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

I'll tell you another thing that really grinds my nose. Don't you just hate it when you're at home, minding your own business, you know just doing the dishes, not bothering anybody, keeping out of harm's way, and then suddenly a global superpower goes and invades another one, pushing the world nearer to another massive war and every single one of us nearer to extinction?

SONG: MEGADETH - SYMPHONY OF DESTRUCTION

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: I hate it when that happens.)

TOMMI

How do you reckon a symphony of destruction would work? Would it be like, the first movement, the woodwind instruments level Tokyo? And then the second movement it gets a bit quieter while the string section undermines Moscow until the percussion comes in with those huge kettle drum things and wipes out eastern Asia?

Or... nah?

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Would you like to hear another thing that really gets on my gears, dear listener of mine? You would? Splendid, then pin them back and I shall tell you.

It's when you ask someone a perfectly ordinary question, and they answer a totally different question because that's what they think you *really* meant to say. It absolutely boils my piss, if you'll pardon my Swedish.

I'll give you an example. Earlier today I asked my flatmate this exact question: Do you know if the supermarket on our street is open today? Pretty simple, right? Pretty direct? I thought so. Potential answers might include "No I don't know", or perhaps "Yep, Blind Tony was yelling about strawberries when I passed earlier". Or if she was in a really pedantic mood she could legitimately say "Yes I do" and I would have no reason to get pissed off at her.

Get this though, this is word-for-word the entirety of her reply:

"I bought butter yesterday."

Ooooookay... thank you for the update, but is the supermarket open or not? I mean, alright, it is obvious why she answered that way, but then I just had to explain "No, I wasn't asking for that reason, I was asking because I need to get some rum for a party after my show tonight and the other booze shop near us was looted last night and is *still* on fire, so do you know if the bastard jumping deep-fried louse-bound sodding supermarket is bloody open or bastard not???"

Winds me up, so it does.

SONG: GREEN DAY - CORVETTE SUMMER

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: This is Green Day.)

TOMMI

Yeeeeeah. Crank it up.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Are you digging the tunes, my dear listener? If you're anything like me - and I know *I* am - then you're having an absolute blast listening to this stuff. And for the most part these guys sound like they're having a whale of a time playing it too.

Some of them can really play too. Check out this next one, by Mr. Big. My granddad's notes say their guitar player was called Pablo Gilberto, and apparently he used to play so fast that he had to keep his guitar in the fridge between recording sessions or the neck would catch fire.

SONG: MR.BIG - ADDICTED TO THAT RUSH

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: Sounds like bullshit to me, granddad.)

TOMMI

I mean... that's a whole lot of notes. Fair play to the lad!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Spirituality! What does that mean to you, listener?

My buddy Bob reckons he's in tune with the spirits... but I think what he really means is that he gets in tune with the day by adding a brandy to each cup of tea. Wrong kind of spirits, Bob my dude, but you do you.

I went out with this girl for a while who was deep into the whole spirituality thing. It didn't work out - to be honest it was a bit much waking up to find crystals on every surface and incense burning in every room. My cat hated that shit, and he pissed in her sandals more than once. (Nice one Jeff.)

Anyway she maintained that the key to a better life was having as open a mind as possible, which I kind of get, but you know... you have to have limits. Last time I saw her was about a month after we split up, and she was absolutely off her chops. She'd been scoffing some dodgy mushrooms with a guy she'd met at a festival, and he'd told her he knew the location of a spring - like a water source, you know - where the water had like life-extending properties or some such, and could I lend her some money... to be honest I'd stopped listening by that point. I made sure she got home safe, made her a cup of NON-hallucinogenic tea (with possibly a large brandy in it), left her dozing safely on her sofa, and went home.

Don't open your mind so far that your brain falls out, is what I'm saying.

SONG: ELECTRIC BOYS - PSYCHEDELIC EYES

TOMMI

Take care of your brain, my dear listener! It's the only one you get!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Dear listener, are you a morning person? Do you spring out of bed when the sun rises, whistling a happy tune, and launch yourself into the day, full of beans and productivity? Ready to tackle whatever London throws at you, sidestepping obstacles in your path, avoiding whatever missiles and curveballs come your way? Dodging the slings and arrows of outrageous fortune, as that guy once wrote?

Sickening.

I dear listener, am not. Even when I'm not here at the mighty C-ROK until the small hours, I am most definitely a night person.

But when I do crowbar myself out of bed, be it afternoon or evening, I am an absolute hot mess until I get at least one cup of coffee down my pie hole. And I don't mean because of a hangover either - thanks to some freak of genetics and/or rigorous beer training, I almost never get those. No I just mean I wake up in a kind of semi-catatonic state, shuffle to the kitchen and like... autopilot the kettle and mug situation with one eye still glued shut, and it's only when the magic beans work their way into what I laughingly call my bloodstream that the gears begin to turn and the magnificent machine that is Tommi Starr rumbles into something approaching cognisance.

So this one is a shout out to coffee and caffeine in all its marvellous delicious forms and flavours.

SONG: THE WILDHEARTS - CAFFEINE BOMB

TOMMI

I love you coffee. Don't ever leave me. Don't you DARE.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

I must ask your indulgence here, my dear listener. I have an apology to make. No names, but you know who you are, and I know you listen. I will be brief.

Yes, I knew you did not like clowns. Yes, I knew you called it a phobia, and yes, I am sorry to say I did not quite believe you. I thought it was silly. I know now that I was wrong, and it is very real to you. Yes, I dressed up as a clown, as scary as I could make it with fangs and fake blood and the whole nine yards, and yes, I got your flatmate to let me into your place and I hid in the wardrobe. I know this was wrong. Please don't blame your flatmate - in her defence she wasn't sure about doing it but I *can* be quite persuasive.

And yes, I did leap out and scream while you were getting ready to go out. I should not have done that.

I will buy you a new dress to replace the one that got destroyed and I have already arranged a repair guy to come round and mend the door, the wardrobe, the shower, the toilet and your bed, all of which I will obviously pay for. I will bring three replacement lamps and a new toaster over to your place tomorrow.

Please don't worry about my arm, it will heal in time, and I expect my eye will be fine once the swelling goes down.

SONG: FORTY DEUCE - OH MY GOD

TOMMI

I really am very sorry, and I hope we can still be friends.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Hey hey hey, my dear listener! How the devil are you doing? You are looking fabulous today! Did you change your hair? You did something. Are those new ears? Either way, you look awesome and I like it.

SONG: BLUES SARACENO - THE DEVIL YOU KNOW

TOMMI

I wish they were all like you, you know. Keep it up. You rock!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

I am absolutely soaked, my lovely listener. Drenched, I am. Listen to this...

Dripping sound effect

That's me wringing out my socks, that is. I was only out there fifteen minutes. I don't know what you've done to the weather lately, but this is not the summer I was hoping for. Look at it out there. It's somehow foggy and pissing down at the same time.

Does that seem right to you?

SONG: ALICE IN CHAINS - RAINIER FOG

TOMMI

Another interesting band name there, that's Alice In Chains with "Rainier Fog". I'm sure there's an interesting story behind that one, but I don't have it to hand. Also, I played that song because of the weather right now, but apparently it's named after Mount Rainier in Seattle, which is where the band came from. So now you know.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

This song absolutely stomps, give it a wee small listen why don't you now just a bit, in fact, as it happens, ever so much, now that you mention it.

SONG: DISTURBED - LAND OF CONFUSION

TOMMI

What was that bit in the middle there? "Men of steel, men of power, are losing control by the hour?"

Eh? Makes you think, doesn't it? Eh? Eh?

Or... makes you drink, maybe. Urgh. Cheers.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

You are listening to "As the World Burns", here on the mighty C-ROK, pirate radio coming in your ears right here in good old London Town, and I'm your host for this hour of power, Tommi Starr.

This next song is from a band called Foo Fighters. Full disclosure: I do not know what a Foo is, or whether I should be fighting them.

Maybe we'll find out?

SONG: FOO FIGHTERS - EVERLONG

TOMMI

So, nope, still no clue what a Foo is or how to fight one. Listener, do you know? Have you ever fought a Foo? Message the show and share your foo fighting experiences.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Tommi Starr here, with "As the World Burns", where I play you the fun rock and metal music that turned up in my granddad's loft.

The management here at C-ROK are very happy with how the show is going, by the way, which is splendid news. So much so in fact that they've asked me to host another show on Sunday evenings, playing old pop classics. The guy who runs the station has this collection of pop stuff from the same sort of era as the rock I'm playing you here. He wants to call it "Father I Have Synth", with Tommi Starr, or something.

I said sure, no problemo, as long as I can keep spinning the rock on Saturdays. The world won't burn itself, now will it!

SONG: BABYLON BOMBS - BABYLON'S BURNING

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: Will it? Will it? Or will it?)

TOMMI

That's Babylon Bombs, with "Babylon's Burning", from Sweden, 2009. Quite a few of these bands from granddad's collection were Swedish, I think. I'll play you another one later. You're welcome.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Hey there, listener, how're you doing today? I am feeling absolutely fantabulous, thanks so much for asking, and I'll tell you wh...

desk phone rings

Ah... that's the telephone in the studio. That's supposed to be off when I'm on the air, dear listener. Sorry about that. Um... I'm just going to answer it or it'll keep ringing, one sec...

answers phone

TOMMI to caller

Hello, who is it? I'm on the air... Bob, is that you? Heyyy man! How did you get through to the studio? Listen I can't talk I'm doing my show right n... hey calm down buddy, what's up? ... Uh-huh ... Yep ... Yeah yeah, your brother, I know... Oh shit, really? ... Can you talk him down? ... Ah crap... I'd come man, but I'm literally on the air right now. Yeah, right now.

TOMMI

Uh, listener, Bob says "Hi".

TOMMI to caller

Well no, obviously I can't come now, man. Shit. OK look, how did you calm him down last time? ... OK, and do you have any of that left? ... Alright what about whiskey or vodka? ... Yeah I know, but it will eventually slow him down. Don't make eye contact, remember! Oh, and show him I dunno, pictures of kittens or puppies or something. Just a sec, man...

TOMMI

I do apologise listener, something has come up, but I will be back with you in just a few moments. Please enjoy some invigorating rock music in the meantime.

SONG: THE LAST VEGAS - WHATEVER GETS YOU OFF

TOMMI (much calmer)

Hello again, dear listener. That was The Last Vegas, with "Whatever Gets You Off" from 2009. Small public service announcement: if you are in the Pimlico area of London tonight and you happen to see a six-foot-eight hugely-muscled-and-tattooed bald dude wearing nothing but a lacy nightgown and makeup on the roof singing show tunes, or in fact anywhere,

please don't make eye contact or draw attention. Ignore him, give him space, and just leave him be. His brother is with him, and he'll be alright in the morning once he takes his pills. Hopefully.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Right, this has gone on far too long enough by half at least, in fact, and I am sick of waiting, dear listener. So, I am going to complain about my landlord. I know nothing will come of it, but I will at least get it off my chest.

First some background.

I've been in my current flat for ten years, and it's been fine. I've had no real complaints about it, and my landlord has been pretty relaxed about letting me modify things over that time, within reason. This arrangement has worked absolutely great up until about two years ago, when he suddenly got in touch to say he was making an update to the utilities. Changing suppliers or something.

Fair enough, I thought, and then that update happened, and... I lost electricity. This happened to the whole building. Everyone in the building complained, naturally, and it took three weeks for that to be fixed. And when I say fixed, it was mostly fixed, for most of us, but a lot of people still had problems. Some of them could no longer use their A/C, some had no heating, you get the picture, but the landlord apparently thought everything was fine, and so people found workarounds - some managed to downgrade their electricity supply to work like it used to, and others got external contractors in to modify their setup, and people kind of just got on with things.

Not ideal, but it worked.

So then, check it, three or four months ago, the landlord gets in touch again and says "Sorry about what happened with that upgrade a while back... but as the building has now been open for ten years, we're going to fix some stuff that's been hanging around, and we have a big surprise for you all - roof garden access is coming!" Now that's a big deal, listener, the roof garden has been rumoured for ages. These flats are nice, but they're small. The plans that went up in the lobby say that the roof garden is 100 square yards of private space, accessible only to residents of the building, which is completely blocked off at the moment.

Well, you can probably guess what happened next. A couple of tiny things got fixed, sure. Some people had their electricity supply reverted to how it was two years ago (which broke their current arrangements), a couple of decorations were changed, there were some new pictures in the corridors and... no roof garden access. No-one can get up there still. Have a guess what they did do though... They installed vending machines in the hallways and lobby, so we can give the landlord more money!

Messages flew, listener, and a month later they said "Oh yeah, sorry, we know you're all waiting for the roof garden thing, it's definitely coming next month, for sure!"

It didn't. It must be pretty much ready, as the noise from the contractors working on it has decreased to the occasional rumble, but the laser grids are still on and we can't get up there. "Next month" has become two months without a single word from the landlord, and all us residents are sick of it!

So, Mr. Hoddward, stop stringing us along and give us what you promised, or just leave the building alone!

SONG: METALLICA - SAD BUT TRUE

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: This is Metallica for you. I'll be doing some breathing exercises, and like... realigning my chi or some such shit.)

TOMMI

To be fair though, it is a really nice building. I love it here, and the rent hasn't gone up in ten years, so you know. It could be worse.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Welcome back, dear listener, I'm glad you made it. When you think about all the things that could have happened to you today, it's a miracle we're both here, really. Let's savour the moment... with Tyketto.

SONG: TYKETTO - FOREVER YOUNG

TOMMI

Hopefully not forever too young, though, right? And by that I mean forever too young to buy beer... that would be awful.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Would you believe what I've got for you now, dear listener? I've got a Freak Kitchen! So there!

SONG: FREAK KITCHEN - NOBODY'S LAUGHING

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: That's the name of the band, by the way. Freak Kitchen. My kitchen is fine. Mostly. I mean, it's not great, but I wouldn't call it Freaky.)

TOMMI

**Impersonates the last notes of the song* Wheeee-woooooowwww...*

Wow that's a good one. Freaking Freak Kitchen, with "Nobody's Laughing". Which is kinda sad, they say laughter's the best medicine, or something like that. Personally I find laughter is great, everyone needs a laugh, but in terms of medicine for what ails you gin just about beats it.

Your mileage my vary.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

No music bed

Pssst, hey you.

Yeah you, I'm talking just to you. This is just for you, the one hearing this now. Yes, you. Everyone else is hearing an advert for talking toasters, this is just for you alone. It's a little radio magic. Come a little closer. That's it, come right close up to the speaker, I need to whisper to you, this is for your ears only. C'm'ere.

Angelic music bed

You're my favourite. You're the best listener. You're number one. Don't tell anyone else you heard this, or they'll be jealous, but I know, and now you know as well. If it wasn't for you, I don't know if I would keep this up. You make it all worthwhile. I love you.

Angelic music stops

OK pretend like nothing happened. 3, 2, 1...

Music bed restarts

Heyyyy listener! I hope you're having an awesome day, filled to the brim with awesomenosity and sprinkled with radical beans.

SONG: LYNCH MOB - WICKED SENSATION

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: And why not? Here's Lynch Mob.)

TOMMI

That's "Wicked Sensation" from Lynch Mob, and that's for my very favourite listener.

You know who you are.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Well, d'you know what dear listener? I was realising that far too often on this show I'm sitting here just complaining to you. "Here's another thing that annoys me" or "Don't you just hate it when" or "Doesn't this get on your nerves too?"

So much negativity! So, I'm taking steps to change that. I'm going to be better. And I'm going to start right now, as it happens, check it out.

Ahem.

Dear listener, here's something that always cheers me right up. You know when you're just walking down the road, minding your own business, and then out of the corner of your eye, you spot a cat just chilling, just sitting still and maybe watching you pass by? Do you do this? OK so check it out, right, next time this happens. If you realise you can see a cat outside, apparently doing nothing, stop. Look right at that cat and stay still. Within about 20 or 30 seconds, you will likely realise that there are at least two other cats somewhere in your field of vision, and that they can see the first cat, and it can see them, and at this point it becomes clear that they are playing a game of cat chess and you have just wandered onto the playing field.

SONG: RAGDOLL - SHINE

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: This is Ragdoll.)

TOMMI

I swear man. Cats. They're playing some metaphysical highbrow game that we're not able to comprehend.

Oh but don't get me started on squirrels. Beady-eyed little bastids.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Listen!

pause music bed

Can you smell something?

SONG: MY CHEMICAL ROMANCE - NA NA NA

TOMMI

That's My Chemical Romance. Shut up and sing it to me.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Someone much wiser - and probably *wider* - than me once said "To better understand someone, walk a mile in their shoes."

I dunno if that works or not, but either way if you do it you're a mile away from them and you've got free shoes.

SONG: CINDERELLA - GYPSY ROAD

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: Here's Cinderella.)

TOMMI

I must point out that we do not endorse shoe theft here on "As the World Burns". That's not cool, sister.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Yes! Welcome back, dear listener, I can't tell you how great it is to be here with you there, kicking back and checking out the rocking sounds of a bygone generation with you. I'm Tommi Starr and this is "As the World Burns" here on the mighty C-ROK, pirate radio coming in your ears right here in London Town.

What do I have for you next, my *dearest* listener? Well, I'm glad you asked, and I'm even more glad you asked so nicely. Up next we have a band from right here in London, called DragonForce. This one's pretty full on, check it out.

SONG: DRAGONFORCE - THROUGH THE FIRE AND FLAMES

TOMMI

Man, that's fun. Wheeeee!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

You're listening to "As the World Burns" here on C-RÖK, and I have just noticed that if you write that down too quickly it looks like "As the Mould Bums". Make of that what you will. Or don't.

pause

Lemme see... can I make a link to the next song based on mould? Ten DJ points if I can make it in five seconds... four... uh...

OK, you don't want mould around in your place because then you might get sick... and this is Mötley Crüe with "Sick Love Song".

SONG: MÖTLEY CRÜE - SICK LOVE SONG

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: That was pathetic, I'm sorry. Zero DJ points, I lose.)

TOMMI

Urgh. I do apologise for that awful link, dear listener. Please don't report me to the DJ police. I don't want to lose my license.

Again.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Check this, I saw some "As the World Burns" graffiti on my way here, which is totally rad, thank you to you dear listener if that was your handiwork. If you wanna check it out, go down to Embankment and on one of the like, bridge supports someone sprayed like a planet earth on fire, and yes the name of the show as well, so it's not a coincidence. Looks awesome, great work with a spray can! Loving it!

Am I endorsing vandalism? Come on girl, this is a pirate radio station so 1) we can endorse what the hell we like, and 2) it's some paint on a bridge support, not smashing up someone's shop or wrecking their home!

It's decoration! And it rocks!

This is LA Guns, with "Lost In The City Of Angels".

SONG: LA GUNS - LOST IN THE CITY OF ANGELS

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: The city of angels... that's... that's Coventry, right?

pause...

Oh wait, no, it's Los Angeles, of course it is.

pause...

Like it's right there in the name. Angeles - angels. Haha, idiot.)

TOMMI

LA Guns there with "Lost in Coventry". Hahahah, what a penis. Sorry listener. Tommi, pull yourself together.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Looks cold out there today, listener, which is crazy seeing as it's August. Foggy too. I was walking here this evening along the banks of the Thames and the fog looked like it was sort of settling on the river... it looked real tranquil and hazy and a bit kinda spooky. I dunno man, I'm not a weather girl.

Made me think of this song, anyway.

SONG: GERARD WAY - HAZY SHADE OF WINTER

TOMMI

That's Gerard Way, and he's the singer from another band I have coming up for you a bit later on.

So sit tight! Don't touch that dial! We'll be right back! And all of that stuff. I'm a pro DJ, me. Hahahaha.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

I tell you something, listener, I am a sucker for a western movie. I used to watch them with my dad who still loves them, because he used to watch them with granddad, and I dunno maybe it goes even further back than that. Maybe it's westerns all the way down, I dunno. But I used to love nothing more than settling down with dad in front of the old Radiation King TV and tuning in for the westerns on a Sunday afternoon.

Anyway my local cinema is showing an absolute cracker at the moment - "A Man and His Dog", with that guy in it with the teeth. You know the one... Hooper or Cooper something? Him. He's great. Real straight-down-the-line honourable cowboy type, dependable, fights for good, defends the weak... you know the kind of thing. We could do with more of those in real life, I reckon.

Heh, my mate Bob reckons that dog in the movie is the actor Hooper's actual dog, because of the way he looks at him, and all that... but I don't think that's how the movie business works, my friend. That is called "acting".

SONG: THE SCREAM - OUTLAW

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: Sticking with a western theme now, this is The Scream.)

TOMMI

Going by the story that I shot in self defence, huh? That's "Outlaw" by The Scream, and I, for one, am not going to argue with that.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

How did it all get like this, dear listener of mine? How did it get so damned shitty out there? Everyone's constantly trying to get one over on the guy next to them, constantly willing to step on someone else's circumstances just to protect their own. Everyone endlessly doing unto others before they do unto you. It's not how life was supposed to be, ladies and gentleman.

Look, I'm not suggesting we upend everything and all go and live in the forest, but come on people, if we just look out for each other a bit, and try and get along, wouldn't life be y'know... better? Just a little?

Give it a try tomorrow. Maybe help your neighbour with their heavy shopping, or give someone at work a hand with something, or wash the dishes without being asked. Little things mount up.

Get your ears around this one, you lovely people.

SONG: SEBASTIAN BACH - HARMONY

TOMMI

We could all do with a little more harmony in our lives these days, I reckon.

Peace, my brothers and sisters.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

You! You there! You are listening to "As the World Burns" on C-ROK!

And I! I Am Tommi Starr!

And this! This is Whitesnake!

SONG: WHITESNAKE - WINGS OF THE STORM

TOMMI

There's a song for ya.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Heyyyy listener, hope you're well this evening here in London Town. If you're feeling a bit down, or a bit tired, or a bit just... meh...

Get this one down your listening holes. This really chugs along.

SONG: AEROSMITH - YOUNG LUST

TOMMI

That's Aerosmith from 1989 with "Young Lust", and that is how we do things around here.

Yessir!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Hey listener, I need to ask a favour. Like off the record. I'm honestly not a big chems guy, but I'm having a bit of trouble lately. I work odd hours, and often need to sleep during the day, but that can be hard and there's noisy work going on in my building, and yada yada yada... so I often end up drifting off with a couple of big old glasses of wine or whatever, which works...

In fact getting home at 5am and sipping Bordeaux on the balcony while the city wakes up around me is pretty fine indeed.

But it's playing havoc with my concentration, man. I'm getting all foggy in the evenings and my memory keeps going for a pie... I need a little something something to bring me back up to a correct operating temperature, you feel me?

So uh... if you happen to know where I can lay my paws on a few boxes of Mentats, I sure would be obliged. Message the show, and hook a brother up, but keep it on the down-low, yeah?

SONG: D-A-D - SLEEPING MY DAY AWAY

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: Safe.)

TOMMI

That's D-A-D with "Sleeping My Day Away". It's not the sleeping that's the problem, boys. It's the getting shit done when I'm awake.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Welcome back, dearest listener, now riddle me this...

How would you like a song about the end of the world?

SONG: CRASHDIET - ARMAGEDDON

TOMMI

Well no, it's not about the end of the world at all, but it *is* called "Armageddon", so y'know. Close enough. That was Crashdiet from 2010, and this is "As the World Burns" with me, Tommi Starr.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Talking of awesome ladies with awesome voices, which I'm sure we were at some point, keep it locked to the mighty C-ROK and check this one out, this is Halestorm.

SONG: HALESTORM - BAD ROMANCE

TOMMI

That was the fabulous Lzzy Hale and her band Halestorm, coming all over you from the year 2011, and my god she could sing, couldn't she? Wonder if I have any more of their stuff in the collection. I'll have a look later on.

But first... this!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

How are you with snakes and the like, listener? I live on the 6th floor of my building and my windows face east, which is mildly annoying for sleeping when your schedule is as uh... unscheduled as mine, but hey. I manage.

Anyway I get the morning sun, and the building opposite me gets the sun in the evening, right? Now, I don't know the people in the flat over the road from mine, I've never even seen them... but I have seen their pets. In the afternoon, when the sun comes over and down and warms the windows opposite, these two massive snakes slither up to the windows and plaster the underside of their bodies against the glass, soaking up the heat. Snakes are reptiles, they're cold-blooded so they have to do this to warm up their systems, you know?

Anyway, these lads are huge. I reckon they must be pythons, from looking in a book or two. Christ they're big, though.

I mean, they fill the glass from floor to ceiling. If you were in the room behind them, it would be like night time, they honestly squish themselves in there like a slithery jigsaw. It's kinda fascinating to watch, but I'm not sure how cool I would be about being in there.

SONG: VELVET REVOLVER - SLITHER

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: I mean... I assume there are people in there too. Like, alive ones.

Shit. Maybe... oh no. I never thought of that. Um. Right.)

TOMMI

You think I should go over there and check? Maybe I should go over there and check. Like, just bang on the door or something, see if anyone answers. Yeah. That would be a good idea, right?

OK. Maybe tomorrow.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Shout out to my pal Robin J up in Camden who's having a bit of a "health whoopsie" as he calls it at the moment. I know it's a bit more serious than he's letting on, but he's styling it out well, so fair play to the guy.

He also said he has to go and have jabs in his... uh... well, not to put too fine a point on it, his... uh... um... dick.

So you know, there's that.

SONG: SIXX A.M. - THIS IS GONNA HURT

TOMMI

Yeah, no. Do not want. Uh uh. No thanks. I'm good, ta.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Here's a band from Scorrerrrtland, aye. Here's a wee song frae a band called Gun, Imma stop doing the accent now, I can't keep it up.

This is Gun from 1994 with "Don't Say It's Over".

SONG: GUN - DON'T SAY IT'S OVER

TOMMI

It is over, though.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Listener! I'm glad I caught you! Did you know that the blue whale is the biggest creature to have ever lived on this here planet? They're still out there in the oceans, and they're wayyy bigger than the biggest dinosaur ever was.

And get this, their hearts weigh about 400 pounds, which is as much as one of those massive Lone Wanderer motorbikes!

Wild!

Also, I may have fallen asleep in front of the TV this afternoon with a wildlife documentary on, and then woke up with twenty minutes to get to the studio, and downed two espressos, three whiskeys and a large shot of this concoction Bob makes in his shed which he calls "Brain Petrol".

He won't tell me what's in it, but damn! I feel amazing!

During that last song, I took all my clothes off!

SONG: GUNS N' ROSES - ROCKET QUEEN

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: (in the style of Archer) Wooooo!

TOMMI

I just went for a quick jog around the block, listener. It's great cardio. You need to look after your heart, you know? Admittedly I should probably have put some clothes back on first. Turns out there are still some people up and about at midnight round here.

Joke's on them though... you can't rob a naked man! Ha!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Now then, my dear listener, I think that you will find that this song absolutely spans - **hard**. Take a little listen, if you could JUST ABOUT BE BOTHERED FOR CHRIST'S SAKE.

SONG: ALIEN ANT FARM - LAST DANTZ

TOMMI

That's the superbly named Alien Ant Farm, with "Last dAntz".

"I don't wanna dance with the dead alone, and be just another ghost on the radio."

Wise words, mate.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI
(sounding down)

Not tonight, listener. I dunno if I've been reading too much news or not getting enough vitamins or what, but I just can't tonight.

Here. Have some music. This is Buckcherry.

SONG: BUCKCHERRY - FALLOUT

TOMMI

Hahahah, "Fallout". Great. That's a **wonderful** thing to think about when this world is getting you down.

I'm sorry listener. Give me a minute. Can you do that? Just give me a minute and I'll get it together.

Thank you.

off mic

Fuck.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

What is up, dear listener? You are enjoying "As the World Burns" with me, Tommi Starr, right here on the mighty C-ROK.

This next band is called Dan Reed Network, apparently. Who was Dan Reed, and why out of my granddad's entire music collection is he the only one to have a network?

Enquiring minds, want to know.

SONG: DAN REED NETWORK - BABY NOW I

TOMMI

Yep, they're the only Network in there, I checked again. There's a couple of Societies, a few trios, a Theater or two, but only one Network.

You were a lucky man, Dan! Cool tune too.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Well, dear listener, would you believe it? Would you in fact Adam and Eve it? It's only "As the World Burns" here on the mighty C-ROK pirate radio, coming in your ears in old London Town!

Next up - this!

SONG: QUEENSRÿCHE - JET CITY WOMAN

TOMMI

Well that dude could sure sing, and a half! That was Queensrÿche from 1990, and that dude was called Geoff, which is my cat's name.

So that's nice.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Well well, dear listener, I have lost a bet. I often say "message the show" when I'm rambling about some shite or other, and lo and behold, someone actually has!

Lemme read this out:

Hi Tommi, love the show. One thing though, could you play more songs with female singers? It's a bit of a schnitzel-fest at the moment.

I think they mean "sausage-fest", but I getcha. They continue:

Could you give a shout out to the girl who serves drinks in my local bar? It's The Admiral Murray in Cheapside and they always play your show, and she works Saturday nights. Her name's Suki Bapswent and I think she might be kinda into me, but I'm shy, and I don't want to blow it. I'm in every Saturday and I'll be wearing a green jacket with blue hair if she wants to get a cider with me after work.

And that's from Rosie M. Suki, if you hear this and you have room in your schedule for a cider with Rosie, look for the blue hair and green jacket. Best of luck to you.

And to try and address your first point, Rosie, this is Evanescence.

SONG: EVANESCENCE - WHAT YOU WANT

TOMMI

It is a sausage-fest, you're right, but I can only play you what I have, I'm afraid. I will try to find some more rockulous ladies in the collection though!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI
(sounding unwell)

Now then, my very dear listener, I am feeling absolutely utterly terrible this evening and it is *not* my fault.

Well not *entirely*.

Well it sort of is a *bit* my fault. But the majority of the responsibility lies elsewhere, my friends.

It was not I who made wine and bourbon so damned enjoyable and more-ish. And it is not my fault that there was a block party in my building last night that went on into today and for all I know is still going on now. That's not on me, no way.

Despite my many and varied talents, I cannot claim to have invented tequila, cigars, blue cheese, or whipped cream, all of which are - to a greater or lesser degree - partially responsible for my current slightly fragile condition.

And to Mary, Alice, Zephyr, Ryan and Chloe, you are all very very naughty people who likely deserve a spanking, but that will have to wait until I have recovered a bit.

This is Vince Neil.

SONG: VINCE NEIL - LOOK IN HER EYES

TOMMI

I think my pancreas has come off. Give me a minute.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

My dear listener, do you enjoy art? Living here in London, even in these dark and stormy times, I am surrounded by opportunities to go to art galleries and museums, yet like most Londoners, I very rarely bother.

If I feel like it, any day of the week I can walk out of my building and within twenty minutes I can be marvelling at a Michelangelo or dazzled by Dali. I can walk right up to and gaze upon actual works by masters like Van Gogh, Kahlo, Monet and Bieber. I can examine the actual brushstrokes made by the actual hands of Rembrandt, Picasso, Clooney and Minogue, all preserved and maintained in perfect condition so that the uneducated masses like myself can wander in off the street, point at these masterworks and say things like "His nose is a bit big, innit?" And "I thought she was supposed to be smiling?"

But do I do any of that? I do not.

No, I rise at the crack of lunchtime, drag myself to the kitchen, consume the two things least likely to kill me from the fridge and a gallon of holy coffee, hang around the flat reading or watching TV until it goes dark then haul myself to whichever one of my current jobs happens to have a shift today, then look for something fun to do in the small hours before the sun chases me back to my cave.

SONG: SLASH'S SNAKEPIT - BEEN THERE LATELY

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: And listener, I love it.)

TOMMI

Shout out to Roast Town in Bethnal Green, by the way. They hook me up with the absolute best coffee around. They have some Kenyan stuff in right now, it's a bit expensive, but it is *well* crisp, let me tell you. It's called... well, it's called "Lion Shit" but that's just marketing.

I think. At least, I *hope* it's just marketing. Either way, it's great stuff. Pow!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Are you still there, dear listener? Are you still with me? Are you still receiving, over?

Are you lying in a darkened room, comfortable, at rest, hanging on my every word, thrilling to the heady combination of rock music from generations past and the idle musings of a fool in a windowless box?

Or are you tearing it up with friends, at a bar or a house party, living your best life and sod the consequences, pour me another one and turn it up DJ?

Or are you doing something else? How and where do you listen to "As the World Burns"? Message the show, let me know. Here's Vain.

SONG: VAIN - GREENER

TOMMI

Most interesting reply wins a signed poster, or something. I dunno. This is pirate radio, we don't normally do competitions. I'll read some of them out, at least.

Peace.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

So I asked a couple of weeks ago where do you people listen to "As the World Burns", and a few of you took valuable entire seconds out of your day to message the show and let me know. I appreciate it, dear listener, I honestly do.

Let me see here, Danielle says she listens to the mighty C-ROK all the time, and on Saturday nights she listens to "As the World Burns" with yours truly as she starts her shift at the morgue where she is a coroner's assistant. Strong start there Danielle, let's see if anyone can top that.

Someone going by RegLord says they listen to "As the World Burns" in their shed, because Saturday night is his wife's book club night, and he's "not allowed" in the house until they've all gone home. Chin up there, RegLord, and if it really bothers you why not start your own book club night instead of complaining about hers, eh?

Joe Snowman says he and his mates have "As the World Burns" on in the background every Saturday night for their weekly session of Dungeons, Dungeons and More Dungeons, which sounds... very exciting I guess. Apparently last week, Smitty G rolled a perfect 38 to defeat an Impossible Beast to a soundtrack of Warrant's "Cherry Pie". Fascinating stuff.

But my favourite message comes from PowerStoat, who writes:

Hey Tommi, love the show. You were asking where people listen, I have a story about that. Me and my mate Johnny the Weasel were fishing in the Thames down by Chelsea bridge one Saturday night. We'd had a pretty good night - we'd caught a perch, a size 9 right boot and a wallet with ten quid in it - and then my hook snagged on something heavy. We managed to slowly work it out of the mud and haul it out, it was a waterproof cooler like they have on boats and that, and there was sound coming out of it as we pulled it up. We got it on the bank and opened it up, and inside was a battery-powered radio and it was playing your show! And the best bit - the song that was playing was called "John the Fisherman!" Now we listen every week. Cheers!

That's wild, PowerStoat. Who'd'a thunk it?

SONG: EXTREME - IT('S A MONSTER)

TOMMI

I love you, listener. Don't you ever forget that.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

This, my very dearest listener, is Black Stone Cherry.

SONG: BLACK STONE CHERRY - BLIND MAN

TOMMI

Damn, I love that one. Proper rock and roll, rocked and rolled properly.
Excellent work, Black Stone Cherries!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

I have Anthrax, dear listener, would you like some? Here!

SONG: ANTHRAX - ROOM FOR ONE MORE

TOMMI

Haha, did you think I meant the bacteria Bacillus Anthracis, or the infection it causes? Haha, no! I meant the metal band from San Francisco in the 1980s! Haha!

I kill me.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Okay my dear listener, we're going to try something a little different now. Following a pork-related comment from a listener the other week, I went back through my granddad's music collection in an effort to find some more female singers, and I did not find very many. What's up with that, granddad?

I found a couple though, and I'm going to play you one of them now. I will just warn you in advance - this is a little heavier than the stuff I generally play here on "As the World Burns". It is *really* good though.

This is Spiritbox.

SONG: SPIRITBOX - PERFECT SOUL

TOMMI

Wooooooo, yeah, that hits *hard*. Cracking stuff. That's "Perfect Soul" from Spiritbox. Vocals by Courtney LaPlante, it seems. Jesus jumping shallow-fried Christ, she can sing. Oof!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

What's up my dear listener? I fervently hope you're well, and that London is treating you right this Saturday evening.

I have a recommendation for you if you're looking for something to do later tonight - a friend of mine is playing a gig at the Rat and Cutter in Hawley Street, and they're on stage sometime after midnight. I'll be heading up there myself once I hand over the studio keys to Abbey at 12.

The band is called Sister Steele, and they play... well have a guess what they play. That's right, it's hard rock all the way, and my pal Mike has one hell of a voice. Check them out if you're around that area tonight, and maybe I'll see you there.

SONG: THE PRETTY RECKLESS - DEATH BY ROCK AND ROLL

TOMMI

That was The Pretty Reckless with "Death By Rock and Roll", which sounds like an interesting way to go.

Coming up on the mighty C-ROK after me it's Abbey Westminster with the Pink Punk Party Hour, so if you're not heading up to Camden to check out Sister Steele, keep it locked to C-ROK, and jam out with her.

Safe.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Listener! Thank heavens you're here! You nearly missed this!

SONG: FURYON - DISAPPEAR AGAIN

TOMMI

That's Furyon with "Disappear Again". Straddling the line between hard rock and metal with effortless aplomb.

Yeah I said it. Aplomb.

What?

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Well, what are you standing around waiting for? Permission? Get on with it, and play some music!

Oh no wait, that's my job.

SONG: LITTLE ANGELS - BONEYARD

TOMMI

That's "Boneyard" by Little Angels, from all the way back in 1991.

Radical.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Listener, I am feeling unusual.

Here are some random facts for you, in no special order:

1. My hectic glamorous lifestyle is such that I don't have any predetermined schedules and routines in my home life. That much is probably no surprise.
2. I do not have a great deal of spare cash to spend on fripperies like clothes.
3. Sometimes the most convenient way of dealing with the laundry is to just leave it all week then stick everything I own in the washing machine when I get home on Friday night or more usually Saturday morning, then dry something on the radiator before my show.
4. There was a power cut in my building today.
5. My flatmate is out of town.

None of those facts on their own add up to very much, but listener allow me to join the dots for you. Every piece of clothing I own was in the washing machine when the power went out, and so when I scrambled back to consciousness roughly an hour ago, I had literally nothing to wear. I mean that, I couldn't even get the stuff out of the machine, the door had locked, and it won't open when the power is off.

So... I can't go to work naked, obviously. But aha, you say! Maybe I can borrow some clothes from the aforementioned flatmate? Sure. Brilliant. Lifesaver. Only if I haven't mentioned it before, my flatmate is a female woman of the opposite sex.

Who is out of town visiting friends, and has taken most of her clothes with her. Certainly all her jeans and t-shirts, it transpires.

And this, dear listener, is why I am feeling unusual, for I sit here before you in a rather fetching red cocktail dress.

SONG: WINGER - RAINBOW IN THE ROSE

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: I will say this. I don't hate it.)

TOMMI

I totally get the thing about pockets now, by the way. This is madness.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Yes yes, dear listener, here we are again, As The World Burns around us.

On that note, here are The Offspring with a public service announcement:

SONG: THE OFFSPRING - THIS IS NOT UTOPIA

TOMMI

So there you have it. Official confirmation. Proof, if proof be need be, that this is *in fact* not utopia.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Well, listener, up next here on "As the World Burns" we have classic British metal from just down the road here in old London Town.

Here's Iron Maiden with "Die With Your Boots On".

SONG: IRON MAIDEN - DIE WITH YOUR BOOTS ON

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: It doesn't get more classic than this.)

TOMMI

And if you don't love that, then I just... I don't know what to tell you. You must be mad, or... both.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Check this next song out, listener. Granddad's notes say that this band was one of the biggest and best of the lot playing this kind of music back in the day, and their guitarist was an utter legend... maybe the most legendary rock guitar player of all time.

Big words, Granddad. Let's see if they can back it up. This is Van Halen, from 1978... nearly 100 years ago!

SONG: VAN HALEN - ATOMIC PUNK

TOMMI

Oh my god, I am in love with that song. The solo, the drums, the guitar sound, the attitude... mmmmm. I want to take that whole song for a long walk down to the beach, maybe grab a couple of tequilas as the sun sets, and see where things go from there.

Mmmmmmmmm.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Yeeeees, my very dearest listener, it's Tommi Starr here on "As the World Burns", but you already knew that.

Next up I have a band called Coheed and Cambria, with a song called "Here To Mars", which I believe is very very long way.

SONG: COHEED AND CAMBRIA - HERE TO MARS

(Over the intro:

*TOMMI: How would you go about measuring how far that is? Sounds
difficult. And... impossible.)*

TOMMI

Great sound, guys, great sound. Love it. Stay tuned for more like that, you lucky people.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Get away from that dial! I saw you! You were thinking about switching stations! How dare you! Bad listener!

Just kidding, do what you like listener, I can't stop you, and I'll be here regardless. It's no skin off my arse.

But if you do switch, you'll miss this next song... which sounds a bit like a guy who's having some really rather impure thoughts about a... well, a er... car.

Um... It's better than it sounds.

SONG: T-RIDE - LUXURY CRUISER

TOMMI

See? That's got a hell of a groove to it, if I'm not very much mistaken.

And I am not.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

This is a fun one, dear listener, hope you dig this, this is David Lee Roth with "Two Fools a Minute".

SONG: DAVID LEE ROTH - TWO FOOLS A MINUTE

TOMMI

Haha I love that bit at the end there, he goes "Shit I gotta be home before the end of the reco- "

pause

Fuck, I have to run. Here's Abbey with the Punk Hour Party Thing, whatever it's called bye...

rushes off

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

With the world in the state it is, you've got to look out for yourself, dear listener.

Now let me explain that. I do **not** mean you've got to just take care of yourself and screw everyone else. Quite the opposite in fact, we're all in this together, and it's too much selfish thinking like that that got us as a race into this situation in the first place.

What I mean is, you have to be able to live with yourself. Personally if I can look back on the day and say "That was an alright day. I didn't make anyone's day worse. I did OK." Then that's enough.

But if I was shitty to someone for any reason, or I half-arsed a job or something and someone else got it worse because of me, then... that plays on my mind, and screws me up in the long hours of the night.

Look I'm not getting all holier-than-thou on you here, dear listener, really I'm not, but shit... if we all just do a tiny bit more than the bare minimum, things would be better for all of us, surely.

And the psychological knock-on effects of failing to do even that, failing to try to be slightly better than a total piece of shit, the the the... mental *fallout* from that... I just can't live with it.

SONG: ALTER BRIDGE - FALLOUT

(Over the intro:

TOMMI: Your mileage may vary of course, but I hope not.)

TOMMI

Sorry listener. Getting a bit maudlin there for a moment. Onwards and upwards!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

As my Finnish neighbour likes to say to me, "If you don't find the wasp in the apple, you already ate it."

I have no clue what he's talking about, dear listener, but he seems sure about it.

Anyway. Here's another London band from way back when, this is Skunk Anansie.

SONG: SKUNK ANANSIE - WEAK

TOMMI

He says another thing as well, what is it? Hang on... something about bears and booze... uh...

Yeah that's it. He said it this morning actually as I was getting home and he was off out to work. He stopped me in the hallway and he said "Tommi, give the beer to the bear you CAN see. Save the vodka for the bear you CAN'T."

Uh... okaaaaayyyyyyy, Sami. Thanks, I guess.

Do you have any idea what he's on about? It's not like I can afford to give vodka away anyhow, to any bear, visible or not!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

My dear, dear listener, it is so good to see you here again, sticking with C-ROK on a Saturday night, here with me Tommi Starr for "As the World Burns".

Now I don't know what was going on in Sweden in the early 2000s, but they sure did have some excellent rock bands.

Here's one of my Swedish favourites from my granddad's box of music, this is Backyard Babies with "A Song for the Outcast".

SONG: BACKYARD BABIES - A SONG FOR THE OUTCAST

TOMMI

Man, that rocks.

I had a go at learning some Swedish, you know. I got as far as "the boy is eating an apple" and my brain blew a gasket. Languages, man, not my thing, I'm afraid.

Pojken äter et epple - something like that!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Liiiiiisten listen listen listen listen listener! Listen, will you, listener!

Are you listening?

...

I love you.

SONG: DANGER DANGER - DON'T BLAME IT ON LOVE

TOMMI

All the way back to 1991 for that one, from Danger Danger, that's "Don't Blame It On Love", and highly rocktabulous it is too.

Mmmmm chewy!

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Well, dear listener, it's time for me to shut down for the night and wander back home through the mean streets of London. Abbey Westminster is up next here on the mighty C-ROK with the Pink Punk Party Hour so stick around for that.

I'll be back here in the throne room next Saturday night, right here, As The World Burns around us.

Peace, y'all. This is The Damned Things. Tommi out.

SONG: THE DAMNED THINGS - LITTLE DARLING

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

So, what do you think happens, dear listener, when you let the eggheads and spooks from the world's most powerful nation go monkeying around with experimental viruses, and DNA rewriting, and all that other lovely stuff that people say is going on over the pond in recent years?

I mean, yeah, on the one hand we could get a cure for cancer or something like that, but get real... the military are holding the purse strings these days. I don't think we can be certain that their intentions are 100% benign, you feel me?

Nothing good's going to come of it, dear listener. Nothing good.

SONG: PHANTOM BLUE - NOTHING GOOD

TOMMI

That's Phantom Blue from 1993, and they are the *only* all-female band I could find in granddad's music collection. Make of that what you will. Or don't.

[cut]

[cut]

TOMMI

Next up, my dear listener, we're serving you up a song released by an English band in 1965, which was then covered by this German band in 2005.

This is Skew Siskin with "My Generation".

SONG: SKEW SISKIN - MY GENERATION

TOMMI

They're from Berlin, they are. My mate Bob went to Berlin once and loved it so much he came back saying he was going to move there. He was getting it all sorted out, too, and then the war in Europe kind of kicked off, and well... that ain't happening any time soon. Does sound like a pretty rad place though.

[cut]